enable them to carry out effectively the purposes for which they were enlisted'.[4] Further, in 1659, the directors of the Company were clear that it was 'their earnest desire by all possible means to spread Christianity among the people of India', which led to missionaries being allowed to travel to Bharat on the Company's ships.[5]

With the cession of Bombay by Portugal to the British Crown in 1661 and the grant of authority over Bombay by the Crown to the Company in 1668, the Company gradually began to move beyond its commercial role towards assumption of political authority. However, it would be a while before the British Parliament recognised this transition. This is notwithstanding the fact that by the 1680s, the Company was seen as an instrument for the creation of a British Empire in Bharat, which resulted in the Charter of 1683, giving the Company the complete powers to 'declare and make peace and war with any of the *heathen* nations of Asia, Africa and America within the charter limits, to raise, arm, train, and muster such military forces as seemed requisite and necessary, and to execute martial law for the defence of their forts, places, and plantations against foreign invasion or domestic insurrection or rebellion' [emphasis added].[6]

The reference to 'heathen' nations, meaning non-Christian nations, is an indication of the religious consciousness of the British coloniser. Further, the Charter of 1683 made it clear that any sovereign powers that the Company may acquire over the territories of Asia, Africa and America, was on behalf of the Crown. Critically, the Company was empowered to set up Admiralty Courts to enforce rights relatable to the Charter, which further deepened its roots. By 1686, the Company was permitted to frame a municipal constitution for Madras. Effectively, in less than 90 years of its entry into Bharat as a trading entity, the Company had managed to establish a framework that had the trappings of a sovereign power.[7]

That the Company was the product of coloniality and the Christian consciousness of the British Crown was established in judicial proceedings in 1683, when it brought an action against another English trader, Thomas Sandys, for directly trading with India in violation of the exclusive rights granted to it by the Crown under the Charter.[8] Among the reasons spelt out by the King's Bench of the England and Wales Court for upholding the legal validity of the Company's action against Sandys under the Charter, one was that the King, as a *good Christian*, ought to be and was deemed to be at war with 'infidels' forever, which applied equally to all his subjects.